

COMMANDING THE ALGORITHM

As tensions flared between India and Pakistan, the loudest applause on social media wasn't for the saffron-tinged chest-thumpers, but for two men usually at the other end—Congressman **Shashi Tharoor** and AIMIM chief **Asaduddin Owaisi.** Tharoor's steadfast defence of India's military action while accusing Pakistan of "spilling Indian blood like sindoor on our soil" on international media platforms came with the former diplomat's characteristic finesse. Owaisi, meanwhile, was unrelenting, calling Pakistan a factory of terrorism and vowing it will be shown its place. No wonder Tharoor and Owaisi's salvos, delivered with surgical precision, ruled the algorithmic battlefield.

Illustrations by **SIDDHANT JUMDE**

▼ OPENING MOVES

KERALA CONG-CHESS

The Congress high command has made its move: **Sunny Joseph**, 72, the MLA from Peravoor, slid into the Kerala PCC chief's post, replacing **K. Sudhakaran**, 76. The subtext here: an overture to the state's Catholic voters, many of whom have of late shown a soft corner for Modi's BJP, ahead of the 2026 state election. There was much cheer on stage as Joseph took over, but sources hint at some drama behind the scenes. AICC general secretary and Kerala in-charge Deepa Dasmunsi had been trying to ease the hot-headed Sudhakaran out, and only a 'promotion' as permanent invitee to the Congress Working Committee kept the peace. In all this, one man lost out: Anto Antony, four-term MP and a favourite of the Gandhis, who saw the post elude him yet again.

